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The Book of Sayings

o.i A household anthology for the people who keep the doors open

These pages were gathered from kitchens, boats, clinics, work sheds, cloisters, and court copies. Some lines are old. Some were made yesterday. Several have been altered by people who wanted a crowd to obey them.

No prophet owns this book. No house owns the lines. Use a saying when it helps you do the next necessary thing. Set it down when it turns a person into a rule.

I

HOW A SAYING SURVIVES

A useful saying has a mouth, a place, a use, and a cost.

“I carry rice” belongs to Suresh on a boat. It is good against hero worship. It does not steer the boat.

“Hospitality has a ceiling” belongs to Mei at a crowded hearth. It protects the people already inside. It can also become an excuse for closing the door.

“Let’s test it” belongs to Eli after a claim has hurt someone. It asks for evidence. It does not tell the injured person to wait quietly.

“No miracles owed” belongs to Somchai at the clinic. It keeps a healer human. It does not excuse a missed dose.

The line is never the whole answer. Look at the hands using it.

2

I. BEFORE YOU ACT

Hold the cup. Do not drink yet.

Heat has a number if you stay.

Name what rose in you. Leave the name there for a breath.

It rose in me. It is not me.

This felt real. I may still be wrong.

Let's test it.

The body can report a danger. The body can also remember one.

When a person says, "My fear is proof," ask what the fear made them do.

When a person says, "My calm is proof," ask what they measured.

2.1 A line people argue over

The map is not the territory.

The harbor crews use it when a clearance sheet sends a boat toward a closed gate. The clinic clerks use it when a record says a patient has already left. A court uses it when it wants the paper to win.

Walk to the gate. Touch the lock. Ask who is waiting on the other side.

3

II. AT THE THRESHOLD

Feed before you file.

Ask before you take the story.

A guest is a guest. A guest is not a deposit toward your certainty.

Hospitality has a ceiling.

Write the number on the wall where everyone can see it.

If there is one bed, say one bed. If there are four bowls, count four bowls.
A promise that hides its limit becomes a trap for the person who believed it.

3.1 From the harbor mouths

“I don’t carry heroes on this boat. I carry rice.” — Suresh, harbor pilot

“Bangla carries you further than English inside.” — Mei, kitchen keeper

“A guest may leave before the meal is finished.” — threshold-house rule,
author unknown

“The living man outweighs the wedding ring on the table.” — Hassan,
witness

The last line is used by people who want to protect a person from an inherited claim. It has also been used to break promises. Ask who was promised what.

4

III. IN THE CLINIC

Wash your hands before you touch the chart.

The clinic treats the body before it decides what the body means.

No miracles owed.

No cure without a person who can say stop.

No measurement without the person affected.

The mark on the door is for finding help. It is not a mark of ownership.

4.1 Somchai's line

"I am the son of a man. He sold fruit. He is dead. I am not a son of anyone who owes you miracles."

The line is copied in clinic rooms. A later administrator shortened it to **SON OF NO ONE OWES** and printed it on a clearance badge. The badge was removed after patients began treating it as a rank.

4.2 The disputed clinic line

First do no harm.

Some keepers mean: do not begin a treatment you cannot stop.

Some administrators mean: do nothing until the paperwork is perfect.

The old nurses add: **A delay has a body too.**

Record the delay beside the treatment. Record who waited.

S

IV. UNDER COMMAND

I carry rice.

A crown needs an end written on it.

The person who gives the order carries the body.

No authority without review.

No review without the person who paid the cost.

An emergency order must say what it is for, who may refuse it, and when it ends.

5.1 The line the posters prefer

If the room needs you, stay.

Commanders like this line. It makes departure sound like betrayal.

The household version is shorter:

Leave while leaving is still allowed.

The second line does not settle the matter. A patient may need the commander for another hour. The commander still owes the room an exit plan.

6

V. AFTER HARM

Name the dead before the lesson.

The clean record can hide a dirty hand.

A correction is not an apology.

An apology is not repair.

Forgive the past. Do not rehire it.

When a person says the loss was necessary, ask whose hands carried it.

When a person says nobody could have known, find the page that was ignored.

6.1 A saying from the receiving corridor

The door opened. The harm still entered.

It was first spoken after a sponsored worker injured Nia at the repair dock. The line does not condemn welcome. It names the work welcome requires: limits, training, witnesses, and a way to stop.

7

VI. WHEN THE CROWD GATHERS

Everyone else is certain.

I alone don't know.

The crowd wants a face. Give it a question.

The crowd wants a title. Give it a task.

The crowd wants a miracle. Give it the bill.

7.1 Parade fragment

Leader: What do we know?

All: What we have measured.

Leader: What do we not know?

All: Why we are here.

Leader: What do we do now?

All: Check the door. Feed the people. Ask again.

The fragment is not an answer to the old question. It is a way to keep the question from becoming someone's crown.

8

VII. WORK AFTER THE ARGUMENT

Wash the bowl.

Put the tools back.

Sweep the floor you are standing on.

Leave the door usable.

Do not perform tomorrow's repair while today's water is still on the floor.

8.1 From the cloister

Paid work before praise.

Room before rank.

Training before trust.

The right to leave belongs in the first agreement.

The cloister copied these lines onto a wall. A recruiter painted over **right to leave**. The residents scraped those words back out with spoons.

9

VIII. FRAGMENTS PEOPLE CARRY

“Information is freight. Silence is ballast. Tell the one who must carry it before the wave hits.” — Wren

“Data walks. Paper crosses borders. The bund holds.” — Hanh

“Clean?” — Asha, before accepting a package

“I’ll meet you in the flow.” — street farewell

“A family remembers whom it has lost. An engine records what the loss purchased.” — Eli

“The next honest task is still here.” — keeper’s note, unsigned

These lines travel because they fit in a pocket. They do not travel with their original circumstances. Carry the circumstance when you can.

IO

IX. POCKET TWELVE

Print one line per card. Post one line per day. Say one under load.

1. **Let's test it.** — when certainty is being sold.
2. **It rose in me. It is not me.** — when a feeling claims the whole person.
3. **I alone don't know.** — when the room wants a clever answer.
4. **I carry rice.** — when someone wants a hero.
5. **Feed before you file.** — when paperwork comes before the meal.
6. **The map is not the territory.** — when the file disagrees with the ground.
7. **Hospitality has a ceiling.** — when the door needs a number.
8. **No miracles owed.** — when a healer is being named sacred.
9. **Name the dead before the lesson.** — when an institution calls harm necessary.
10. **A crown needs an end.** — when emergency power feels comfortable.
11. **Wash the bowl.** — after the argument.
12. **Leave the door usable.** — before you leave.

II

HOW TO USE THE BOOK

Choose a line that belongs to the work in front of you. Say who taught it if you know. Say that you may be wrong if you do not.

Do not use a saying to end an argument that still has a person waiting in it. Do not use a clinic line to avoid treatment. Do not use a household line to claim a household. Do not use a question as a substitute for the next honest task.

When the crowd leaves, count the bowls. When the record changes, keep the old page. When the authority ends, check whether the room can still act.

The full litanies remain separate. This book keeps the fragments that ordinary people can carry.